LESSON 3

Discernment in Biblical Herbalism

Creator Worship • Creation Stewardship • Spiritual Boundaries

Course: NHMEC Biblical Herbalism Foundations
Module: Module 2.1 — Biblical Herbalism
Lesson: Lesson 3
Instructor: Min. Penny Lane Whittemore CNC BCNWP CHGp RHCH CHHWC
Education Center: Natural Health Ministries Education Center
Learning Hub: PENothecary™ Membership Website

Lesson Overview

In Lesson 1, we learned that Biblical Herbalism begins with God as Creator. In Lesson 2, we learned that a Christian herbalist is a servant, educator, and steward who honors God while teaching responsibly.

In this lesson, we will focus on one of the most important foundations of Biblical Herbalism:

Discernment.

Discernment is the ability to recognize what is of God, what is not of God, what is safe, what is wise, and what should be avoided. This is especially important in herbal study because herbs are often discussed in many different spiritual, cultural, traditional, and modern wellness spaces.

A Christian can study herbs without practicing witchcraft.
A Christian can grow herbs without worshiping the earth.
A Christian can make tea without using spellwork.
A Christian can enjoy creation without bowing to creation.

Biblical Herbalism does not teach fear of plants. It teaches reverence for God, respect for creation, and wisdom in how we study and practice.

Lesson Scripture Foundations

1 John 4:1 KJV

“Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God…”

Deuteronomy 18:10–12 KJV

“There shall not be found among you any one that maketh his son or his daughter to pass through the fire, or that useth divination, or an observer of times, or an enchanter, or a witch,
Or a charmer, or a consulter with familiar spirits, or a wizard, or a necromancer.
For all that do these things are an abomination unto the LORD…”

Romans 1:25 KJV

“Who changed the truth of God into a lie, and worshipped and served the creature more than the Creator…”

James 1:5 KJV

“If any of you lack wisdom, let him ask of God, that giveth to all men liberally, and upbraideth not; and it shall be given him.”

Proverbs 3:5–6 KJV

“Trust in the LORD with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding.
In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths.”

Lesson Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students should be able to:

1. Define biblical discernment.
2. Explain the difference between Creator worship and creation worship.
3. Identify herbal practices that may conflict with Christian faith.
4. Explain how to study herbs without adopting ungodly spiritual practices.
5. Understand why prayer, scripture, and wisdom are necessary in herbal education.
6. Create a personal spiritual boundary statement for herbal study.
7. Practice safer language when discussing herbs from a Christian worldview.

Opening Teaching

Discernment is not fear.

Many Christians become nervous when they hear the word herbalism because they have seen herbs connected with witchcraft, New Age spirituality, spellwork, astrology, divination, earth worship, moon rituals, or occult practices. Because of this, some believers reject all herbal study without realizing that herbs themselves were created by God.

On the other side, some people become so fascinated with plants that they begin to give spiritual power to the plant itself. They may treat herbs as magical objects, spiritual guides, energy tools, or replacements for prayer, scripture, repentance, wisdom, or God Himself.

Biblical Herbalism must avoid both extremes.

We do not fear what God created.
We do not worship what God created.

We study herbs with biblical order.

God is Creator.
Plants are creation.
Christ is Lord.
The Holy Spirit is our guide.
Scripture is our foundation.
Wisdom is necessary.
Discernment is required.

A Christian herbal student must learn how to separate plant knowledge from spiritual error.

What Is Discernment?

Discernment is the ability to judge wisely between truth and error, light and darkness, wisdom and foolishness, God's way and man's way.

Discernment helps the Christian herbal student ask:

Does this teaching honor God?
Does this practice agree with Scripture?
Does this method involve divination, spellwork, sorcery, or occult ritual?
Does this teacher give spiritual power to plants?
Does this practice cause confusion, fear, pride, or idolatry?
Can I study this herb while keeping Christ first?
Am I being led by the Holy Spirit or by curiosity without boundaries?

Discernment does not mean we reject learning. Discernment means we learn carefully.

Discernment does not mean we are afraid of every herb. Discernment means we test the spirit behind the practice.

Discernment does not mean we become judgmental. Discernment means we remain faithful to God's Word.

Creator Worship vs. Creation Worship

One of the most important distinctions in Biblical Herbalism is the difference between Creator worship and creation worship.

Creator Worship

Creator worship means we honor God as the Maker of all things. We thank Him for plants, food, medicine, beauty, fragrance, and provision. We recognize that creation points back to Him.

Creator worship says:

“God made this.”
“God provided this.”
“God deserves the glory.”
“God gives wisdom.”
“God is the healer.”
“God is above creation.”

Creation Worship

Creation worship happens when a person gives honor, spiritual power, devotion, or trust to created things instead of God.

Creation worship may sound like:

“The plant is my healer.”
“The herb has spiritual power over me.”
“The earth is my source.”
“The moon charges my medicine.”
“The plant spirit guides me.”
“The universe is directing my healing.”
“This ritual gives the herb power.”

Romans 1:25 warns against worshiping and serving the creature more than the Creator. For the Christian herbalist, this warning matters.

We may appreciate creation.
We may study creation.
We may use creation wisely.
We may grow herbs.
We may prepare herbs.
We may teach about herbs.

But we do not worship creation.

Herbs Are Not Evil

It is important to say this clearly:

Herbs are not evil.

God created plants before man fell into sin. Herbs, trees, seeds, and fruit were part of God's creation. Genesis tells us that God saw what He had made, and it was good.

The problem is not the plant.
The problem is how people may use the plant.
The problem is the spirit behind the practice.
The problem is idolatry, deception, sorcery, or false worship.

A plant can be used as food.
A plant can be studied for wellness education.
A plant can be used in a tea.
A plant can be grown in a garden.
A plant can be used in a salve.
A plant can be used in cooking.

Those are not automatically occult practices.

However, if the plant is used in spellwork, divination, ritual worship, conjuring, spiritual manipulation, or as a replacement for God, then the Christian must reject that practice.

Practices a Christian Herbal Student Should Avoid

A Christian herbal student should avoid herbal practices that involve or promote:

Witchcraft
Sorcery
Spellwork
Divination
Fortune-telling
Necromancy
Calling on spirits
Spirit guides
Plant spirit worship
Moon rituals as spiritual power
Astrology-based herbal rituals
Charging herbs with spiritual energy
Manifestation rituals
Occult symbolism
Charms or enchantments

Using herbs to control another person's will
Curses, hexes, or binding rituals
Any practice that replaces prayer with spiritual manipulation

The Christian student must also be cautious with language that gives herbs spiritual authority they do not have.

We do not say:

"This herb has a spirit that will guide you."
"This plant will protect you spiritually."
"This tea removes curses."
"This herb gives you power."
"This ritual activates the plant."

Instead, we can say:

"This herb has traditionally been used for general wellness support."
"This plant was valued historically for food, fragrance, or household use."
"This herb may be studied for its traditional uses and safety profile."
"We thank God for His creation and ask Him for wisdom."

Practices a Christian Herbal Student May Study Responsibly

A Christian herbal student may responsibly study:

Biblical plants
Kitchen herbs
Herbal teas
Herbal oils
Salves
Poultices
Herbal baths for general comfort
Traditional herbal preparations
Herbal gardening
Herbal safety
Plant identification
Herbal history
Nutrition
Food as stewardship
Whole-person wellness
Prayer and scripture for encouragement
Herbal education for family and community wellness

The difference is not always the herb itself. The difference is the worldview, intention, practice, and spiritual authority attached to it.

A cup of peppermint tea is not witchcraft.
Growing rosemary is not witchcraft.
Learning about garlic is not witchcraft.
Making calendula oil is not witchcraft.
Teaching herb safety is not witchcraft.

But using herbs for spells, divination, spiritual control, or occult ritual is not compatible with Biblical Herbalism.

The Danger of Mixture

Mixture happens when a Christian tries to combine biblical faith with practices that do not honor God.

Mixture may look harmless at first. It may be presented as wellness, empowerment, self-care, intuition, energy, manifestation, ancestral spirits, goddess spirituality, or earth-based spirituality. Some of these practices may use beautiful language, but the Christian must examine the root.

A Christian herbal student must ask:

Is this rooted in Scripture?
Does this practice honor Jesus Christ as Lord?
Does this require me to call on another spirit?
Does this ask me to trust spiritual power outside of God?
Does this lead me away from prayer and the Word?
Does this make me dependent on rituals instead of God?
Does this confuse my witness as a Christian?

Discernment protects the student from mixture.

Biblical Herbalism must stay clean, clear, and Christ-centered.

The Difference Between Tradition and Occult Practice

Not every tradition is occult.

Many cultures have used herbs for food, comfort, daily care, and household wellness. Traditional herbal knowledge may include observations passed down through families and communities. A Christian can learn from history and tradition while still testing everything through Scripture, safety, and wisdom.

However, some traditions may include spiritual practices that conflict with Christian faith. The student must learn to separate useful plant knowledge from spiritual practices that should not be adopted.

For example:

Studying chamomile as a calming tea is herbal education.
Using chamomile in a spell to control someone is not biblical.

Studying frankincense in Scripture is biblical plant study.
Burning incense to call spirits is not biblical.

Using olive oil as food or skin support is practical stewardship.
Believing oil has power apart from God is error.

Learning about herbs from history is education.
Participating in rituals that invoke false gods is not acceptable for the Christian.

Discernment helps us keep the knowledge and reject the error.

Prayer as Protection and Guidance

Prayer should be part of the Christian herbal student's study life.

Before studying, pray.
Before teaching, pray.
Before preparing herbs, pray.
Before giving educational guidance, pray.
Before reading from unfamiliar sources, pray.
Before attending herbal events, pray.

Ask God:

"Lord, give me wisdom."
"Lord, help me recognize truth from error."
"Lord, keep me from deception."
"Lord, help me honor You."
"Lord, show me what to keep and what to reject."
"Lord, let my studies glorify You."

Prayer is not superstition. Prayer is relationship with God. Prayer keeps the Christian student humble, dependent, and spiritually alert.

Scripture as the Foundation

Scripture is the foundation for Biblical Herbalism.

This does not mean the Bible is an herbal encyclopedia. The Bible does not list every herb, every preparation, every safety concern, or every modern research detail. But Scripture gives us the worldview, boundaries, and wisdom we need.

Scripture teaches us:

God created the earth.
God provides food from the earth.
The body matters.
Wisdom matters.
Discernment matters.
Idolatry must be avoided.
Sorcery must be rejected.
Prayer is important.
Compassion is required.
God is the ultimate healer.

When the Christian herbal student is unsure, they should return to Scripture, prayer, wise counsel, and safety.

Discernment Questions for Herbal Resources

When reading an herbal book, watching a video, attending a workshop, or learning from a teacher, ask:

1. Does this resource honor God or remove Him?
2. Does this teacher give spiritual power to plants?
3. Are occult practices included?
4. Are herbs presented as magical?
5. Are unsafe claims being made?
6. Are disease cure claims being made?
7. Does the teacher encourage people to reject medical care?
8. Is fear used to sell products?
9. Is the information balanced and responsible?
10. Can I use the plant information while rejecting unbiblical spiritual elements?

These questions help students become wise learners.

Discernment Questions for Personal Practice

Before using or teaching an herbal preparation, ask:

1. Why am I using this herb?
2. Am I trusting God or the herb?
3. Am I using safe educational language?
4. Am I making claims I should not make?
5. Have I checked safety concerns?
6. Is this within my scope?
7. Could this person need medical care?
8. Have I prayed for wisdom?
9. Would this practice honor Christ?
10. Could this confuse another believer?

Discernment is not only about what we reject. It is also about how we practice what we keep.

Safe Christian Language for Herbal Study

A Christian herbal student should use language that is both faith-filled and responsible.

Instead of saying:

“This herb heals.”

Say:

“God is the healer, and this herb has traditionally been used to support general wellness.”

Instead of saying:

“This plant has spiritual power.”

Say:

“This plant is part of God’s creation, and we study it with gratitude and wisdom.”

Instead of saying:

“This formula cures disease.”

Say:

“This preparation is shared for educational purposes and general wellness support only.”

Instead of saying:

“You do not need a doctor.”

Say:

“Please consult a licensed healthcare provider for medical concerns.”

Instead of saying:

“This ritual activates the herb.”

Say:

“We pray for wisdom and thank God for His provision.”

Words matter. The Christian herbalist must speak in a way that protects the student, honors God, and avoids confusion.

Teacher’s Teaching Notes

When teaching this lesson, be gentle but clear.

Some students may have come from New Age, occult, or mixed spiritual backgrounds. Others may have been afraid to study herbs because of those associations. This lesson should not shame students. It should bring clarity, peace, and biblical order.

Teach students that Biblical Herbalism is not fear-based. It is Christ-centered.

The message is not:

“Be afraid of herbs.”

The message is:

“Honor God, use wisdom, reject what is unbiblical, and study creation responsibly.”

Students should leave this lesson feeling grounded, not confused.

Student Reflection

Answer the following questions in your notebook or student workbook.

1. What does discernment mean to you?
2. Why is it important to test the spirit behind herbal teachings?
3. What is the difference between Creator worship and creation worship?
4. Why are herbs not evil in themselves?
5. What makes an herbal practice spiritually unsafe for a Christian?
6. How can a Christian learn from herbal traditions without adopting unbiblical practices?
7. What herbal language should Christians avoid?
8. How can prayer and Scripture protect your herbal studies?

Optional Discussion Board Prompt

Post your answer inside the PENothecary™ student space:

What is one way a Christian herbal student can practice discernment while still appreciating God's creation?

Respond to at least one classmate with encouragement, scripture, or a thoughtful reflection.

Vocabulary Words

Discernment: The ability to recognize truth from error and judge wisely according to God's Word.

Creator Worship: Honoring God as the Maker, Provider, Sustainer, and ultimate healer.

Creation Worship: Giving devotion, spiritual power, or trust to created things instead of God.

Occult Practice: A spiritual practice involving hidden, forbidden, or unbiblical spiritual power such as divination, sorcery, witchcraft, or spirit communication.

Mixture: Combining Christian faith with practices that do not align with Scripture.

Spiritual Boundary: A clear decision about what a Christian will and will not participate in.

Safe Herbal Language: Responsible wording that avoids medical claims, magical claims, and spiritual confusion.

Lesson 3 Summary

Discernment is essential in Biblical Herbalism. A Christian can study herbs, grow herbs, prepare herbs, and teach about herbs without compromising faith. The key is to honor God as Creator, reject creation worship, avoid occult practices, and remain rooted in Scripture.

Herbs are not evil. They are part of God's creation. However, some practices connected to herbs may not align with biblical faith. The Christian herbal student must learn to separate plant knowledge from spiritual error.

Remember:

Do not fear what God created.
Do not worship what God created.
Study with wisdom.
Pray for discernment.
Test the spirit behind the practice.
Reject occult practices.
Use safe language.
Keep Christ at the center.

Closing Prayer

Father God,

Thank You for giving wisdom freely to those who ask. Help me walk in discernment as I study herbs and creation. Teach me to honor You as Creator and never worship what You have made.

Protect me from deception, mixture, pride, fear, and confusion. Help me recognize what aligns with Your Word and what does not. Give me courage to reject anything that dishonors You and wisdom to study responsibly.

Let my herbal education be clean, Christ-centered, safe, and rooted in truth. Help me use knowledge with humility and serve others with compassion.

In Jesus' name,
Amen.

Instructor Closing

Students, discernment is not a one-time lesson. It is a lifelong practice.

As you continue studying Biblical Herbalism, you will read books, hear teachings, watch videos, attend classes, and encounter many different views. Not everything you hear will be biblical. Not everything you hear will be safe. Not everything you hear will be wise.

Test everything.
Pray often.
Stay humble.
Stay grounded in Scripture.
Reject what dishonors God.
Keep what is true, safe, and useful.
Give God the glory.

This is how we study herbs as Christian herbalists.